

THE PLEASURE PRINCIPLE

2024

Looking for a therapist is always a big challenge for me. I know I can take pretty much any therapist to their knees if I choose to. And it starts so innocently, too:

Therapist: "How are you doing today?"

Me: "I hate everyone"

T: "Why do you hate everyone?"

M: "I just get so annoyed at how they go around every day acting as if any of this matters to anything. They get emotionally invested in all these things that make no difference to anything. That by itself wouldn't bother me, but then they try to pull me into the shit and I'm expected to pretend like it matters to me or I'm a weirdo. It just gets so exhausting."

T: "Can you give me an example?"

M: "Sure, pick literally anything. Take politics, for example."

T: "How does politics make no difference to anything? Surely having different people in charge making different decisions regarding public policy makes a

difference, no?"

M: "Not on any scale that matters. Who really cares about the policy decisions of a race of chimps on a tiny insignificant dust ball on a remote arm of an utterly unremarkable spiral galaxy?"

T: "Well, I would have to say 8 billion chimps do."

M: "And when our sun inevitably becomes a red giant and envelopes the Earth; what then? Nothing we've ever done or ever will do will matter. It will be as if we never existed."

T: "First, that event is literally billions of years from now. Second, there are far more grave threats to humanity that need solutions now. If you're given to seeing things in this way, then why not work to solve the more imminent threats to humanity's ongoing existence?"

M: "You mean stupidity? I don't know how to solve that. I've tried many times and all I get is "TL;DR" in response. I think they're too far gone."

T: "No. I mean like climate change, environmental conservation, nuclear weapons nonproliferation, (counter-pandemic) immunity research, or most recently working to ensure that AI doesn't get out of control."

M: "In other words, why not spend my life in a Sisyphean struggle to save humanity from itself?"

T: "I'm sorry, I'm going to need you to define sissyfeein for me."

M: "In Greek mythology, Sisyphus (not to be confused with syphilis) was a tyrant who, upon death, was sentenced to roll a boulder up a hill only to have him become exhausted just prior to reaching the summit and having to let the boulder roll back down the hill again. He repeats this endlessly for eternity."

T: "Oh, of course, you just caught me off guard with that one. You do have quite the vocabulary. But back to the discussion, why do you think that

fighting to save the environment, for example, is futile?"

M: "Because poisonous ideas, most notably capitalism, have entrenched themselves in the minds of nearly everyone in the world. Capitalism is an economic model based on the idea that we should do whatever other people want us to do. While I'm sure that seemed very innocent, or even elegant, when it was conceived, what they failed to anticipate was the need to do things that no one wants to do to ensure our survival as a species. Thus, capitalism disincentivizes doing the things we need to survive ...until the threat has begun to affect people's lives directly. At which point, it's usually far too late to stop it."

T: "OK... But that's why the concept of non-profit organizations exists. They get to operate outside of the capitalist model for that very reason."

M: "Put down the Kool-Aid. That is not even close to true. Non-profit organizations are exempt from paying taxes on donations and grants. They are also exempt from most cases where sales tax would normally apply. That's all. They are still subject to other taxes, like payroll tax, etc. And if they do have income through any other means, such as selling candy bars, that's taxable as usual. While the exemption does allow a non-profit to theoretically work independently of the 'free' market, it doesn't allow them to escape the basic idea upon which capitalism was built.

"Don't think for a second that grant money is free money; it comes with plenty of strings attached. People aren't just blindly handing over millions of dollars and just assuming that it will be used in some way to forward the organization's mission. They want to see their money used for very specific things and have metrics upon which to evaluate the organization's progress toward those objectives. Failing to meet the agreed-upon annual targets results in less funding next year. So you're still dancing to the beat of someone else's drum all the same.

"Furthermore, it means that your non-profit can only do work that other people have already thought of and want to fund which eliminates the possibility of doing anything original or innovative. You're limited to taking

the funds available to do things you're capable of doing rather than what you want to be doing. That just happens to also be the definition of employment."

T: "Alright. Clearly, you've put a lot of thought into this. So, what's the solution, then?"

M: "Fundamentally, the problem with capitalism is that it assumes that people know what they want and that what they want is what is best for them. While that certainly should be the way it works, we both know it isn't. As you're well aware, people are motivated primarily by fear and avoiding pain.

"This kind of thinking is problematic because it leads to ideas like Libertarianism, which is the very embodiment of 'Fuck you, I'm from Texas!' Reacting to fear encourages individualistic thinking because the world is seen as a threat that needs to be guarded against. As a single monkey, I am limited in what I can defend. As such, I am only capable of looking out for myself, my wife, and my children. To that end, I build or purchase a suitable fortification to keep us safe from any physical threats that might exist in the environment and also ensure that there is some amount of land buffering my fortification from those of other monkeydoms."

T: "I see. Go on..."

M: "This mentality permeates everything we do. And while it helps bolster this ephemeral notion of safety, it runs counter to the very tangible experience of happiness. We're happy when we're around others who are well-intentioned and want the best for us. But people who are scared and just trying to avoid pain are the same ones who will trip you if you find yourselves running from a bear."

T: "We're still just focusing on the problem though. What is the solution?"

M: "Quite simply: Hedonism. Rather than run away from what frightens you, run toward what you want. Natural threats will exist, but trust in others to have your back as they trust you to have theirs. Build an economic model based

on that and then you've got something worth talking about as soon as this house of cards we're in now inevitably comes crashing down."

T: "But isn't that too just bowing to man's lower nature? Would everyone not just get high and have sex all day?"

M: "At first, many people would go that route. I would, for example. But that's only because of the accumulated pressure of having lived their lives unable to express those urges. But as the hippies so conveniently exemplified, sex, drugs, and rock 'n roll get old eventually and the need for a more enriching purpose in life usurps one's desires. Some people may find this deeper fulfillment in procreation. Heck, even I might consider wanting to knock someone up if it were no longer so blatantly unethical to do so! But most will find satisfaction in helping to keep their communities safe and operating well. Notice the shift from 'fortifications' to 'communities'. It seemed so natural, didn't it? I think that's a major clue."

T: "As a therapist, I can't argue with you. Almost all I do these days is treat people for depression stemming from loneliness. The best part of your concept is that it might leave me without a job! Regardless, you cannot change society by yourself, so what can you do to influence the course of human progress so that your lovely vision could perhaps come to be one day?"

M: "I don't know."

AI DRINKING GAMES

2025

AI can be a lot of fun if you put some imagination into it. First, I fed ChatGPT the essay, The Pleasure Principle, then I offered the following prompt:

"Hypothetical: Lon Milo DuQuette, Dion Fortune, and a fictional philosophy professor from Cambridge were at a bar together arguing about the merits of The Pleasure Principle. What issues might they be arguing about and what might a transcript of the conversation look like? One last thing: there is a standing rule that each person must drink a shot of rye whiskey before they are allowed to speak."

CAST

Dion Fortune – Esoteric psychologist, sharp-tongued spiritual pragmatist.

Lon Milo DuQuette – Occultist trickster, friendly chaos surfer.

Dr. Reginald Hawthorn-Smythe – Dry British philosopher, allergic to optimism.

Standing Rule: Everyone must take a shot of rye whiskey before speaking.

ACT I: THE COSMIC SHRUG

Fortune: (tilting back her rye like it's medicine)

"This essay is either a cry for help or a master class in psychic shielding. Possibly both. The patient sees no meaning, no stakes, no continuity beyond the veil of entropy. What surprises me is that he hasn't lost his mind completely."

DuQuette: (shoots rye, sighs wistfully)

"Not lost it, Dion—just misplaced it in the Akashic records. Honestly, I admire him. That 'tiny dustball in a remote spiral arm' thing? Been saying that since the Nixon administration. But unlike most cynics, he still wants to want something. That's the seed of magic right there."

Dr. Hawthorn-Smythe: (raises eyebrow, downs his rye, winces)

"The patient—excuse me, the author—uses cosmological scale as an epistemic bludgeon. Classic move. 'Nothing matters because the sun will eventually explode.' Convenient dodge. He's right, but he's using it to opt out of responsibility."

Fortune: (calmly)

"He's not opting out—he's mourning. This is grief masquerading as reason. He knows people are suffering, he knows systems are broken, but he's overwhelmed by the inertia of stupidity. That's not apathy. That's psychic exhaustion."

ACT II: CAPITALISM, KOOL-AID, AND CONSENT

DuQuette: (pours another rye with reverence)

"His dissection of capitalism is sharper than most occult critiques I've read in decades. He gets that it's not just an economic model—it's a magical spell. A memetic virus that trains people to value desire as dictated by others."

Dr. Hawthorn-Smythe: (grudgingly impressed)

"He nails the structural flaw: capitalism presumes rational actors who know what's good for them. But people are driven by fear. That part was Freud-worthy. Possibly Jungian. And the analysis of nonprofits? Cynical, yes, but

devastatingly accurate.”

Fortune: (quietly)

“His frustration is rooted in empathy, not disdain. He cares that no one else sees the problem. He cares so much, it makes him angry. That’s why he’s dangerous—not because he hates people, but because he once loved them and got burned.”

ACT III: HEDONISM AND REDEMPTION BY COMMUNITY

DuQuette: (leans back, grinning after a shot)

“And then—bam!—he pivots to hedonism. Like, pure pleasure principle as salvation. Run toward joy instead of away from fear. That’s not just a philosophy—that’s Thelemic gospel. ‘Do what thou wilt shall be the whole of the Law,’ anyone?”

Fortune: (a bit sharper now)

“It’s charming. Naïve, perhaps, but charming. He’s underestimating just how much fear is baked into the bones of society. But the instinct is pure: build trust, not walls. Community, not fortresses. He’s halfway to a magical order without realizing it.”

Dr. Hawthorn-Smythe: (clearly moved, trying not to show it)

“The most surprising moment is when he admits: ‘I don’t know.’ That humility saves the entire essay from being just another intellectual tirade. He’s not offering a utopia—he’s reaching for one. That matters.”

DuQuette:

“And let’s not forget that final image—where he actually considers creating life, not in spite of the system, but after it collapses. That’s hope. Unrefined and uncomfortable, but hope nonetheless.”

Fortune:

“Perception creates reality. But only trained perception can transmute suffering into power. Otherwise, the psyche becomes its own parasite.”

DuQuette:

“Damn, that’s good. Can I put that on a t-shirt?”